Shiv Nadar University Chennai

CS3807 – Deep Learning Laboratory

Experiment 7

End-to-End Study of Autoencoders, Convolutional Autoencoders, Denoising Autoencoders and Variational Autoencoders

Degree & Branch	B.Tech Artificial Intelligence & Data Science	Semester V
Subject Code & Name	CS3807 – Deep Learning Laboratory	AY: 2026–27

1. Objective

The objective of this experiment is to develop an end-to-end understanding of autoencoders and their variants for image representation, reconstruction, denoising and generative modeling.

The experiment begins with a fully connected autoencoder, progresses to a Convolutional Autoencoder (CAE), introduces image corruption for denoising, and finally develops a Variational Autoencoder (VAE). Students will visualize the learned latent representation, compare reconstruction quality using quantitative and qualitative measures, and explore the generative capability of the VAE.

The same image dataset and a controlled experimental protocol should be used throughout the experiment wherever possible.

2. Learning Outcomes

After completing this experiment, students will be able to:

- explain the encoder–latent–decoder structure of an autoencoder;
- prepare image data for reconstruction-based learning;
- implement a fully connected autoencoder;
- implement a Convolutional Autoencoder for image reconstruction;
- introduce controlled noise and build a denoising autoencoder;
- evaluate reconstruction using MSE, MAE and SSIM;
- visualize and interpret latent representations;
- explain the probabilistic latent representation of a VAE;
- implement the reparameterization trick;
- calculate and interpret reconstruction and KL-divergence losses;
- generate new images by sampling from a learned latent space; and
- compare deterministic and variational latent representations.

3. Dataset and Experimental Setup

Dataset: MNIST Handwritten Digit Dataset

MNIST contains grayscale images of handwritten digits from 0 to 9. Each image has spatial dimensions

$$28 \times 28 \times 1.$$

The dataset was loaded directly using Keras/TensorFlow:

`https://www.tensorflow.org/api_docs/python/tf/keras/datasets/mnist`

Laboratory subset used: A stratified subset of 10,000 training images and 2,000 test images (seed = 42) was used for all experiments. Pixel values were normalized from $[0, 255]$ to $[0, 1]$.

Digit	Training Count
0	987
1	1,124
2	993
3	1,022
4	974
5	904
6	986
7	1,044
8	975
9	991

The stratified sampling keeps all ten classes close to balanced ($\approx$ 900–1,124 images each out of 10,000).
The labels are not required as reconstruction targets. The original image is the target:

$$\boxed{x \rightarrow \text{Encoder} \rightarrow z \rightarrow \text{Decoder} \rightarrow \hat{x}}$$

where x is the input image and $\hat{x}$ is its reconstruction.

4. Source Code

The complete implementation (fully connected autoencoder, convolutional autoencoder, denoising convolutional autoencoder, variational autoencoder, and all reconstruction/latent-space analyses) is available at the following GitHub repository:

`https://github.com/PolarFox08/Deep-Learning-Lab/tree/main/Deep%20Learning%20Lab%207`

5. Expected Input and Output

Expected Input

Each input image has shape

$$28 \times 28 \times 1.$$

For a batch of 32 images:

$$X \in \mathbb{R}^{32\times28\times28\times1}.$$

Pixel values should be converted from

$$[0, 255] \rightarrow [0, 1].$$

For a fully connected autoencoder, the image may be flattened:

$$28 \times 28 = 784.$$

Therefore,

$$x \in \mathbb{R}^{784}.$$

For a convolutional autoencoder, retain the spatial structure:

$$x \in \mathbb{R}^{28\times28\times1}.$$

Expected Output

The primary output is a reconstructed image:

$$\hat{x} \in \mathbb{R}^{28\times28\times1}.$$

Students must display:

```
Original image
Reconstructed image
Reconstruction error
```

For the denoising model, display:

```
Original clean image
Noisy image
Denoised reconstruction
```

For the VAE, display newly generated samples obtained by sampling from the latent distribution.

6. Overall Experimental Pipeline

The complete experiment follows:



The experiment consists of four related studies:

1. Fully Connected Autoencoder
2. Convolutional Autoencoder
3. Denoising Convolutional Autoencoder
4. Variational Autoencoder

7. Exploring Autoencoders

An autoencoder learns to reproduce its input at the output.
The encoder maps the input to a lower-dimensional representation:

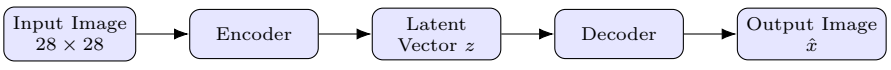
$$z = f_\theta(x),$$

and the decoder reconstructs the input:

$$\hat{x} = g_\phi(z).$$

The training objective is to minimize reconstruction error:

$$\mathcal{L}_{rec} = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N} \|x_i - \hat{x}_i\|^2.$$



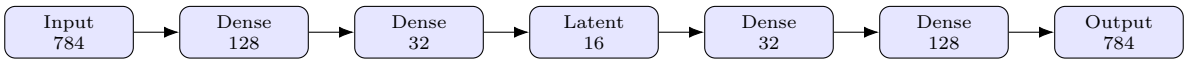
The latent vector is a compressed representation of the input.

8. Fully Connected Autoencoder

Flatten each image from

$$28 \times 28 = 784$$

to a vector of length 784.
Architecture used (matches the suggested configuration exactly):

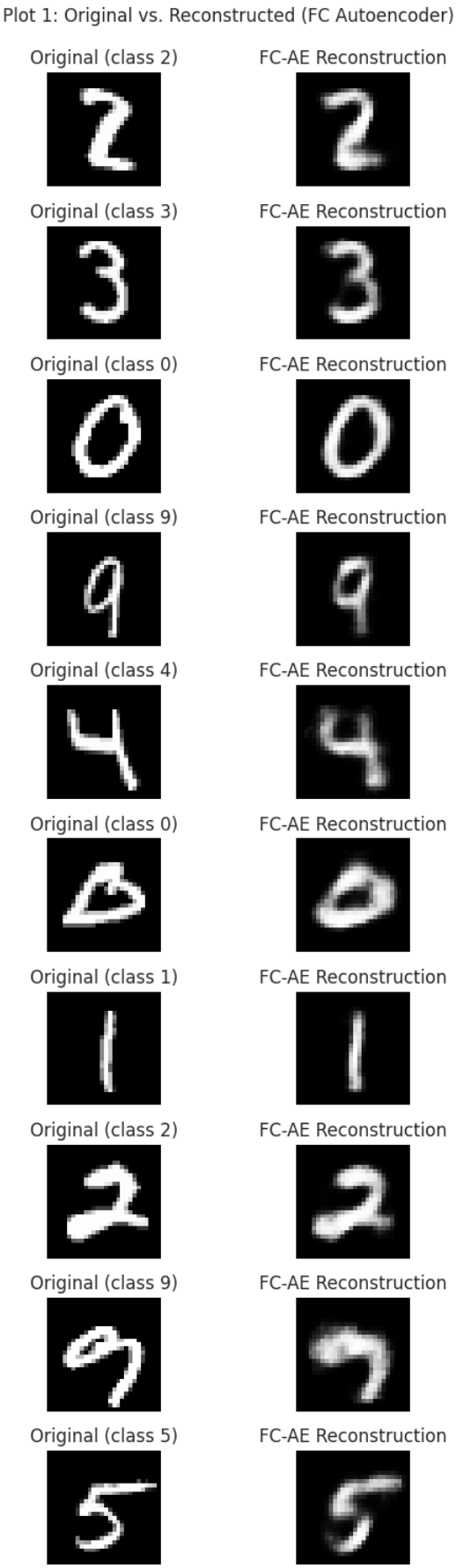


ReLU activation was used in hidden layers and sigmoid activation in the output layer.
Configuration used:

Parameter	Value
Latent dimension	16
Optimizer	Adam
Learning rate	10^{-3}
Batch size	128
Epochs	20
Loss	Binary Cross-Entropy
Total parameters	211,040

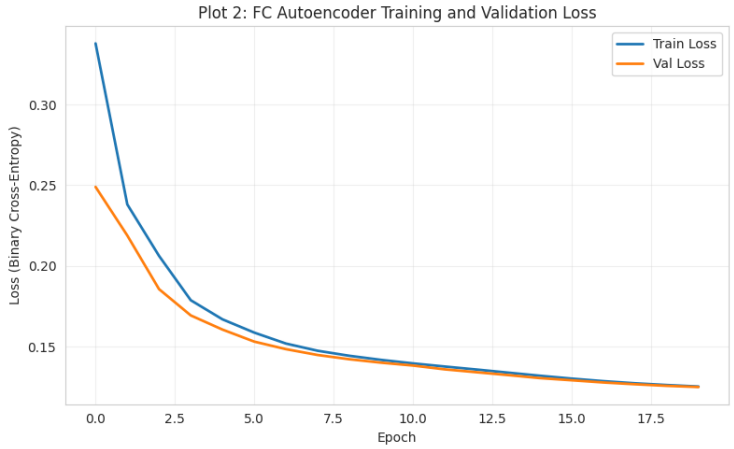
9. Required Analysis of the Basic Autoencoder

Plot 1: Original versus Reconstructed Images



Inference : All the digits were reconstructed and are legible to read, but noticeably blurrier compared to the input. Simple straight stroked-digits like 1 and 4 and simple curves like 0 are reconstructed more sharper, but slightly complex digits like 9 and 5 are less clear and more blurry. This is consistent with a fully connected network having to reconstruct every pixel independently from a 16-dimensional bottleneck with no explicit notion of spatial locality.

Plot 2: Training and Validation Reconstruction Loss



Required inference: Both curves look similar and converge at a similar value too. This is expected as the dataset is the same MNIST and hence no drift in distribution or anything else. No evidence of overfitting found too.

10. Reconstruction Metrics

Students must calculate the following metrics on the test set.

Mean Squared Error

$$MSE = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}(x_i - \hat{x}_i)^2.$$

Mean Absolute Error

$$MAE = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}|x_i - \hat{x}_i|.$$

Structural Similarity

Calculate SSIM between the original and reconstructed images.
The implementation may use:
`https://scikit-image.org/docs/stable/api/skimage.metrics.html`

Metric	Value
Test MSE	0.021037
Test MAE	0.056284
Mean SSIM	0.7621

11. Convolutional Autoencoder

A Convolutional Autoencoder preserves spatial structure and uses convolutional operations in the encoder and upsampling operations in the decoder.
The implementation used:

```
Input(28,28,1)
Conv2D(32, 3, activation='relu', padding='same')
MaxPooling2D(2, padding='same')
Conv2D(64, 3, activation='relu', padding='same')
MaxPooling2D(2, padding='same')
Conv2D(64, 3, activation='relu', padding='same')
UpSampling2D(2)
Conv2D(32, 3, activation='relu', padding='same')
UpSampling2D(2)
Conv2D(1, 3, activation='sigmoid', padding='same')
```

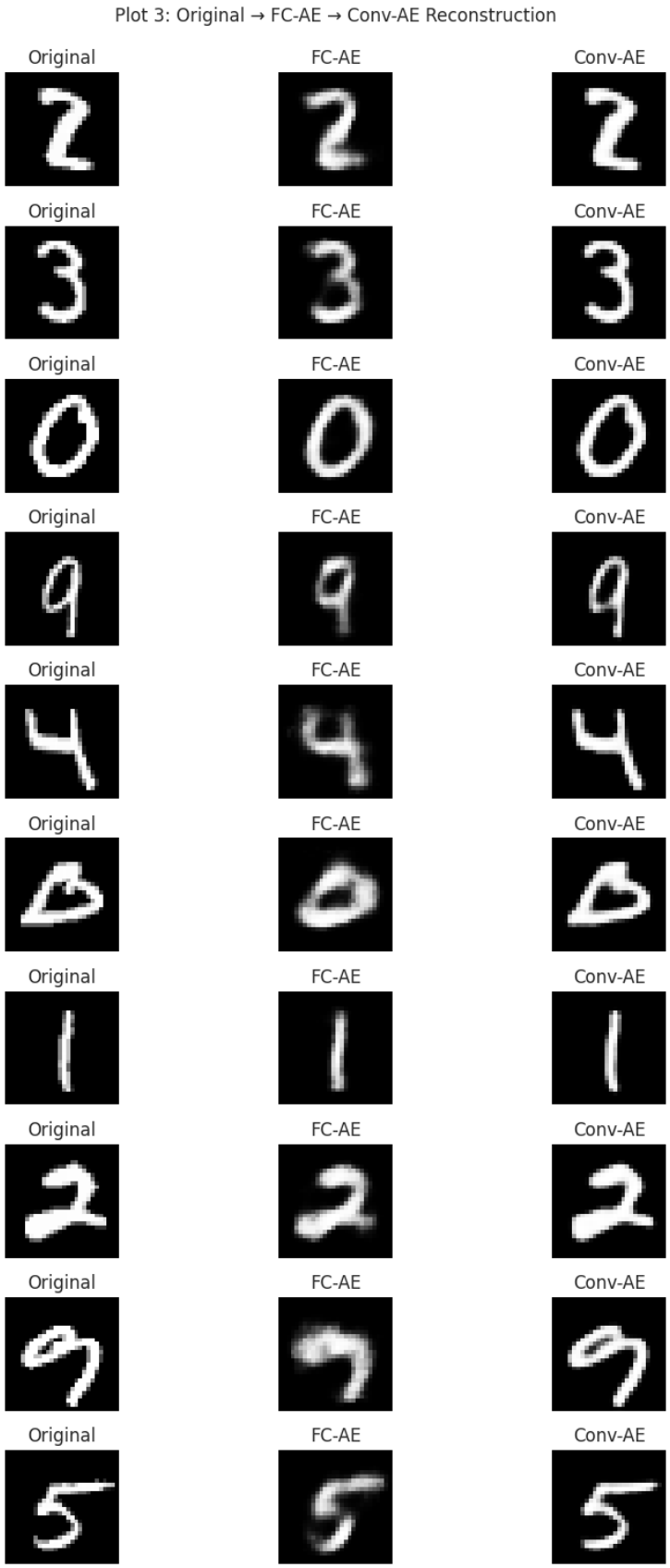
(UpSampling2D was used rather than Conv2DTranspose; see Section 30, Exercise 4 for the untested transposed-convolution variant.) Same optimizer/loss/batch size/epochs as the FC autoencoder (Adam, lr = 10^{-3}, BCE, batch 128, 20 epochs). Total parameters: 74,497.

12. Comparing Fully Connected and Convolutional Autoencoders

Both models were trained using the same training and test images.

Model	MSE	MAE	SSIM	Parameters
Fully Connected AE	0.021037	0.056284	0.7621	211,040
Convolutional AE	0.002561	0.015044	0.9746	74,497

Plot 3: Reconstruction Comparison



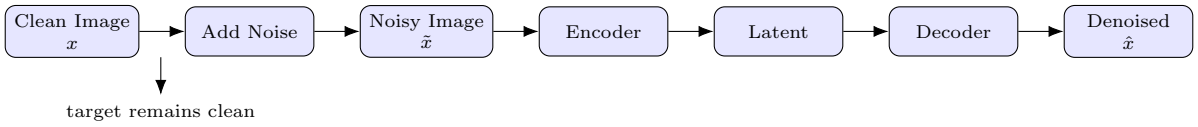
Required inference : Even with less paramters Conv-AE images are much more sharper and closer to the original images compared to FC-AE. This is because spatial property is preserved through convolution as each pixel gets a value based on its neighborhood pixels rather than a flattened bottleneck. Curly images (9,5,3) are very sharp and their curves and holes are more defined and closer to actual, thanks to convoultion's spatial property.

13. Denoising Autoencoder

A denoising autoencoder receives a corrupted image but is trained to reconstruct the original clean image.
The training mapping is:

$$\boxed{\tilde{x} \rightarrow \text{Encoder} \rightarrow z \rightarrow \text{Decoder} \rightarrow \hat{x}}$$

where $\tilde{x}$ is a noisy version of the clean image x. The same Conv-AE architecture as Section 11 was reused for the denoising model (74,497 parameters), trained with noisy input → clean target, using Gaussian noise at $\sigma = 0.2$ as the main training noise level.



14. Adding Image Noise

Gaussian Noise (implemented and evaluated)

$$\tilde{x} = x + n, \qquad n \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2).$$

Standard deviations used:

$$\sigma \in \{0.1, 0.2, 0.3\},$$

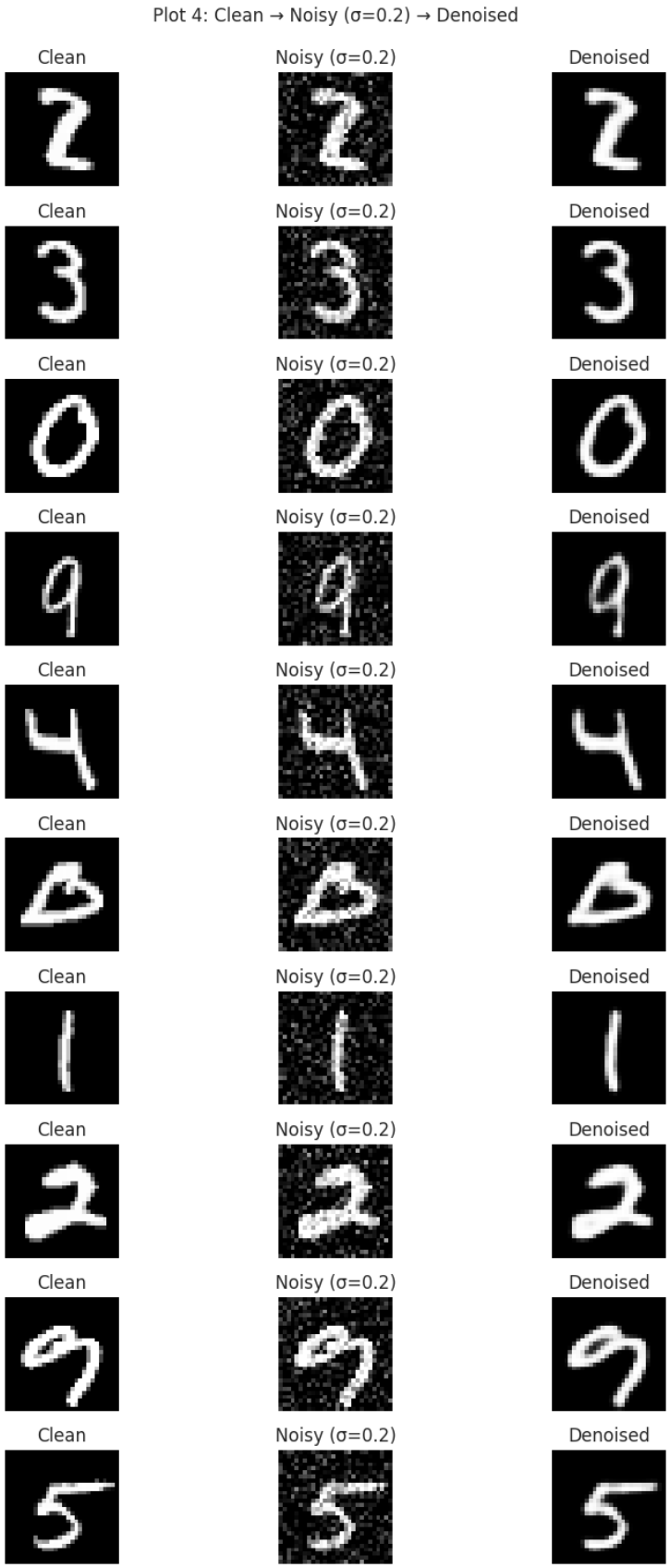
clipped to $[0, 1]$. The denoising model was trained once, at $\sigma = 0.2$, and evaluated against noisy test images at all three levels.

Salt-and-Pepper Noise (implemented but not evaluated)

A salt-and-pepper corruption function was implemented in the notebook (randomly replacing a proportion of pixels with 0 or 1), but no salt-and-pepper denoising model was actually trained or evaluated in this run – see Section 30, Exercise 2.

15. Required Denoising Plots

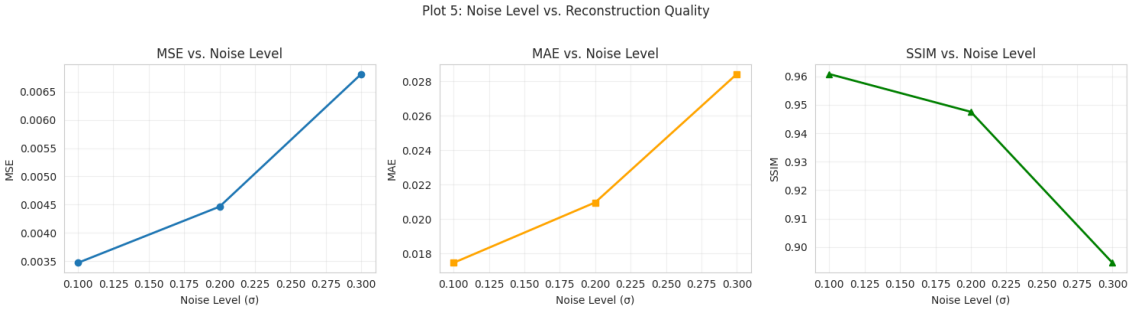
Plot 4: Clean vs. Noisy vs. Denoised



Inference : At $\sigma = 0.2$, the input images gets heavily mixed with random extreme pixels making some of the strokes look illegible. However the AE is able to learn the natural strokes and produce an almost similar copy of the actual numbers, with very mild variations

Plot 5: Noise Level vs. Reconstruction Quality

Noise Level (σ)	MSE	MAE	SSIM
0.1	0.003471	0.017457	0.9608
0.2	0.004465	0.020965	0.9475
0.3	0.006812	0.028429	0.8945



Required inference: MSE and MAE loss rise roughly linearly while SSIM decreases linearly as noise increases from $\sigma = 0.1$ to 0.3. This is the expected output as the more a number a gets corrupter the more the loss will be while the structural similarity decreases. The error at max noise is still very less and the model would be able to figure out the natural strokes and denoise the numbers easily.

16. Variational Autoencoder

A conventional autoencoder maps an input to a deterministic latent vector:

$$z = f(x).$$

A VAE instead learns a probability distribution:

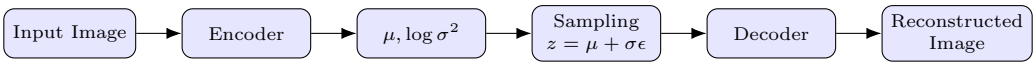
$$q_\phi(z|x) = \mathcal{N}\left(\mu(x), \mathrm{diag}(\sigma^2(x))\right).$$

The encoder produces:

$$\mu, \qquad \log \sigma^2.$$

A latent vector is sampled using the reparameterization trick:

$$z = \mu + \sigma \odot \epsilon, \qquad \epsilon \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I).$$



17. VAE Loss Function

The VAE objective consists of two components.

Reconstruction Loss

$$\mathcal{L}_{rec} = -\mathbb{E}_{q_\phi(z|x)}[\log p_\theta(x|z)].$$

Binary cross-entropy was used, scaled by 28×28 (summed rather than averaged over pixels) to balance it against the KL term.

KL Divergence

$$D_{KL}\left(q_\phi(z|x) \parallel p(z)\right) = -\frac{1}{2}\sum_j \left(1 + \log \sigma_j^2 - \mu_j^2 - \sigma_j^2\right).$$

The total loss is

$$\boxed{\mathcal{L}_{VAE} = \mathcal{L}_{rec} + \mathcal{L}_{KL}}$$

where the prior is

$$p(z) = \mathcal{N}(0, I).$$

Training configuration used: Adam, lr $= 10^{-3}$, batch size 128, 30 epochs, trained on the 10,000-image training set with **no held-out validation split** (`vae.fit` was called without `validation_data`).

Epoch	Reconstruction Loss	KL Loss
1 (first)	191.63	2.62
30 (final)	140.65	3.55

Total loss fell from 194.26 (epoch 1) to 144.19 (epoch 30). Reconstruction loss dropped substantially and monotonically over training, while KL loss rose only slightly (2.62 $\rightarrow$ 3.55) and stayed small relative to the reconstruction term – the model prioritized fitting the data while keeping the latent distribution only mildly regularized toward the prior.

18. VAE Implementation

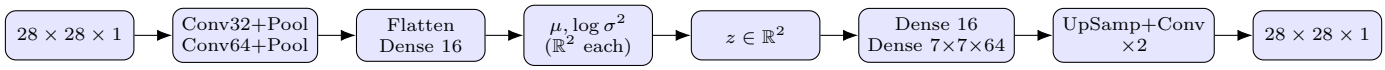
A small, 2-dimensional latent space was used so that it can be visualized:

$$z \in \mathbb{R}^2.$$

The encoder produces:

$$\mu \in \mathbb{R}^2, \qquad \log \sigma^2 \in \mathbb{R}^2.$$

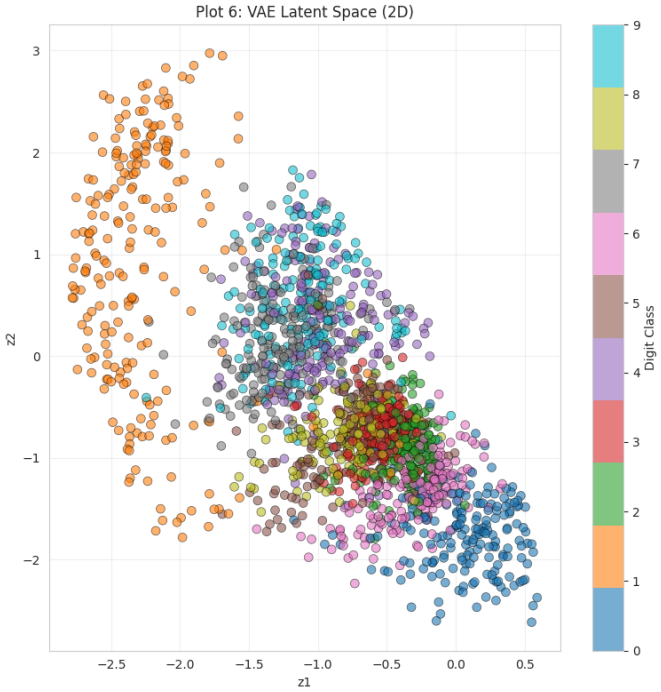
The implemented architecture was:



Total trainable parameters: 70,594.

19. Exploring the VAE Latent Space

Since the latent dimension is two, the encoded test images can be visualized in a two-dimensional plane.
Plot 6: VAE Latent Space



Required inference : Digits 1 and 0 form visually separating clusters. Other digits like 3,8 and 7,9,4 form heavily overlapping regions. This indicates the 2 dimensional bottleneck is not enough to linearly separate all 10 digits without overlaps (even though points of a specific digit form tight regions)

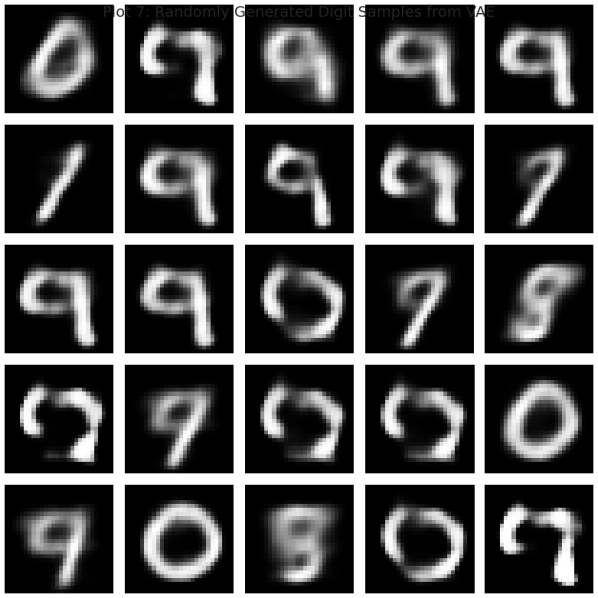
20. Generating New Images with the VAE

Sample points from

$$z \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I).$$

Pass the sampled latent vectors through the decoder.

Plot 7: Randomly Generated Images



Inference : The generated digits are recognizable but have a very small diversity in them with mostly digits like 9,8 and 0s generated most of the time. This is because the mean of the latent space distribution is filled with overlaps of these numbers (3,8,6,7,9) so the generated data also resembles these digits (circles and a flat line). This low-diverse sampling can be seen as a disadvantage of VAEs.

21. Latent Space Interpolation

Select two latent vectors:

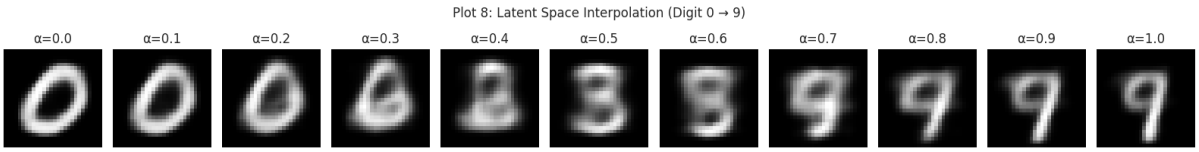
$$z_A, \qquad z_B.$$

Construct

$$z(\alpha) = (1-\alpha)z_A + \alpha z_B, \qquad \alpha \in [0,1].$$

11 values were used ($\alpha = 0, 0.1, \ldots, 1.0$), interpolating between the encoded means of a test digit **0** (z_A) and a test digit **9** (z_B).

Plot 8: Latent Space Interpolation



Required inference : The decoded image changes smoothly and continuously along the path: a clean 0 ($\alpha = 0$–0.2) gradually closes and tilts into a 6-like shape ($\alpha \approx 0.3$–0.5), then thickens into an 8-like/ambiguous shape ($\alpha \approx 0.6$), before opening into a clear 9 ($\alpha \approx 0.7$– 1.0). There are no abrupt jumps or unrecognizable/broken intermediate frames anywhere along the path, confirming the learned latent space is locally continuous and semantically meaningful in this region, not just a lookup table of memorized points.

22. Reconstruction Comparison Across Models

Model	MSE	MAE	SSIM	Parameters
Fully Connected AE	0.021037	0.056284	0.7621	211,040
Convolutional AE	0.002561	0.015044	0.9746	74,497
Denoising CAE ($\sigma = 0.2$)	0.004465	0.020965	0.9475	74,497

For the VAE, its reconstruction loss is reported separately because its total objective also contains the KL-divergence term.

VAE Metric	Value
Reconstruction Loss (final epoch, BCE-based)	140.65
KL Loss (final epoch)	3.55
Total Loss (final epoch)	144.19
Test MSE	0.045464
Test MAE	0.108695
Mean SSIM	0.4865

The VAE's test-set MSE/MAE/SSIM are clearly worse than all three deterministic autoencoders above – expected, since (a) its latent space is only 2-dimensional (a much tighter bottleneck than the FC-AE's 16 or the Conv-AE's $7 \times 7 \times 64$ feature map) and (b) its loss trades off reconstruction fidelity against the KL regularization term, rather than optimizing reconstruction alone.

23. Required Plots

The final report contains the following plots:

1. Original image versus reconstructed image. (Section 9, Plot 1)
2. Training and validation loss for the basic autoencoder. (Section 9, Plot 2)
3. Fully connected AE versus convolutional AE reconstruction. (Section 12, Plot 3)
4. Clean versus noisy versus denoised images. (Section 15, Plot 4)
5. Noise level versus MSE/MAE/SSIM. (Section 15, Plot 5)
6. VAE latent-space visualization. (Section 19, Plot 6)
7. Randomly generated VAE images. (Section 20, Plot 7)

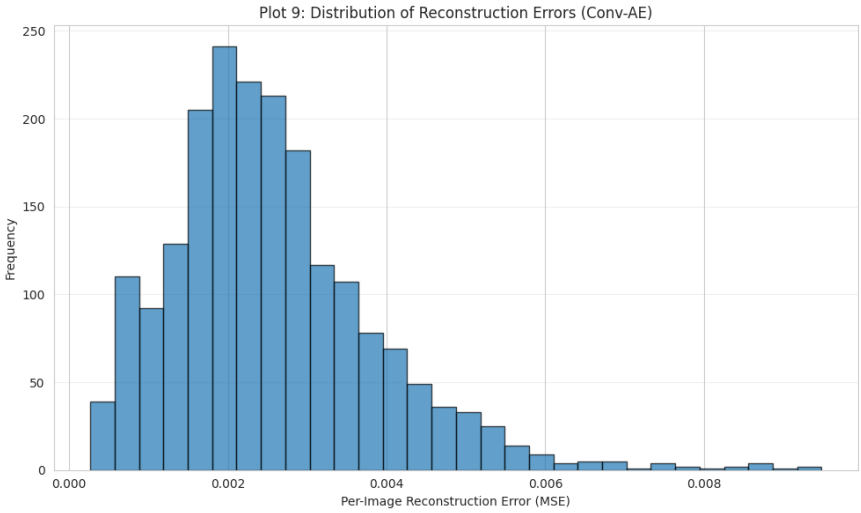
8. Latent-space interpolation. (Section 21, Plot 8)
9. Training/validation reconstruction loss for the VAE.
10. Reconstruction-error distribution on the test set. (Section 24, Plot 9)

24. Reconstruction Error Distribution

Calculate the per-image reconstruction error:

$$e_i = \frac{1}{D}\sum_{j=1}^{D}(x_{ij} - \hat{x}_{ij})^2.$$

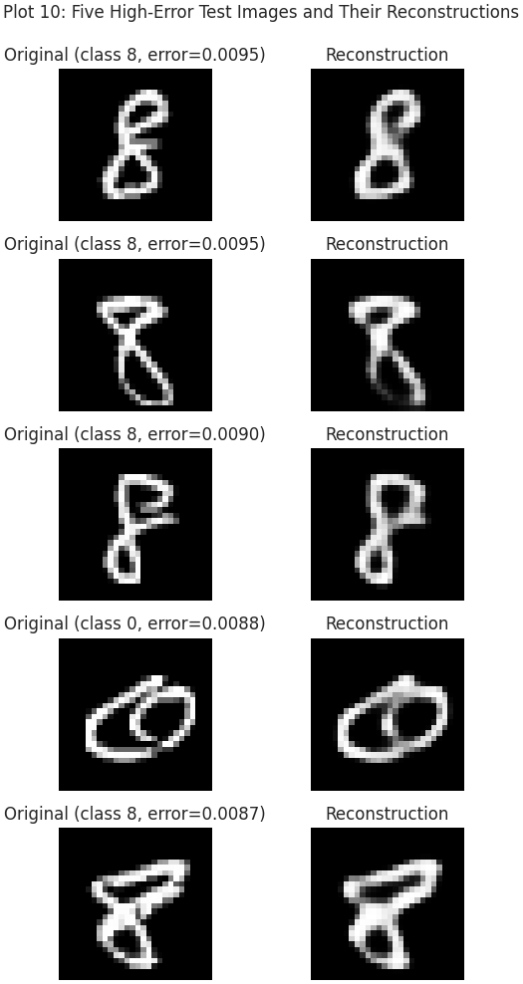
Plot 9: Distribution of Reconstruction Errors (computed for the Convolutional Autoencoder, the best-performing deterministic model)



Inference : The the bulk of the 2,000 testimages have a per-image MSE between roughly 0.0015 and 0.003, with the distribution being heavilry right-skewed. So the typical reconstruction error is small and tightly clustered, but a minority of harder samples (the tail) drive up the mean MSE noticeably above the mode.

25. Required High-Error Image Analysis

The five test images (Conv-AE) with the largest reconstruction errors:



Sample	True Class	Error (MSE)
1	8	0.0095
2	8	0.0095
3	8	0.0090
4	0	0.0088
5	8	0.0087

Explanation : All of these images resembles an 8 somewhat. This implies the model find self- intersecting loops like 8 and looped 0 the most difficult. The reconstructed images are still recognizable but the details like the intersection area and the curves are blurry.

26. Consolidated Results

Model	MSE	MAE	SSIM	Parameters
FC Autoencoder	0.021037	0.056284	0.7621	211,040
Conv. Autoencoder	0.002561	0.015044	0.9746	74,497
Denoising CAE	0.004465	0.020965	0.9475	74,497
VAE	0.045464	0.108695	0.4865	70,594

27. Required Inferences

For every major plot, students must write a short inference containing:

1. What does the plot show?
2. What trend is observed?
3. Why might the observed trend occur?
4. What conclusion can be drawn?

These are provided alongside each plot above (Sections 9, 12, 15, 19–21, 24–25). The following mandatory inferences are covered in the sections indicated:

- effect of latent dimension on reconstruction – Section 28;
- difference between fully connected and convolutional reconstruction – Section 12;
- effect of Gaussian noise level – Section 15 (Plot 5);
- ability of the denoising autoencoder to recover image structure – Section 15 (Plot 4);
- characteristics of the VAE latent distribution – Section 19;
- structure of the two-dimensional VAE latent space – Section 19;
- quality and diversity of generated samples – Section 20;
- smoothness of latent-space interpolation – Section 21;
- relationship between reconstruction error and visual quality – Sections 24–25;
- differences between deterministic and probabilistic latent representations – Section 22.

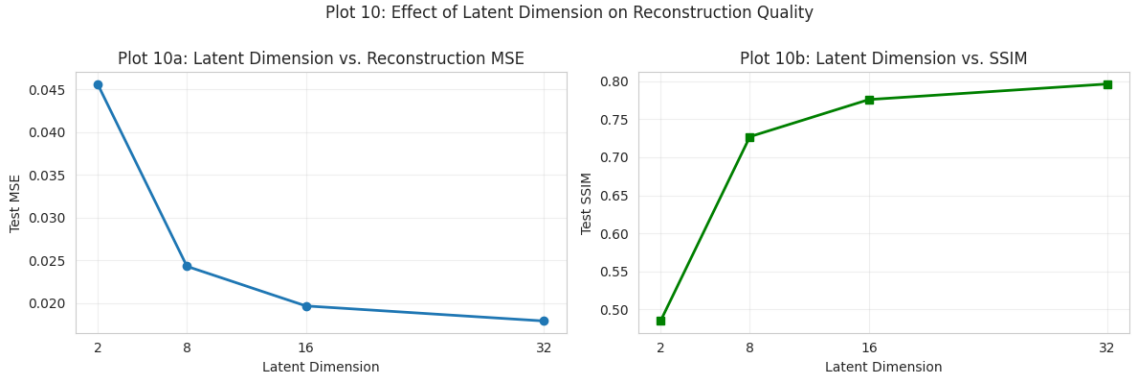
28. Additional Latent-Dimension Study

The basic (FC) autoencoder was retrained from scratch with:

$$d_z \in \{2, 8, 16, 32\}.$$

Latent Dimension	MSE	SSIM	Parameters
2	0.045616	0.4849	210,130
8	0.024291	0.7270	210,520
16	0.019654	0.7758	211,040
32	0.017896	0.7962	212,080

Plot 10: Latent Dimension vs. Reconstruction MSE / SSIM



Inference: Both curves show significant gains initially as the latent dimension increases but at the 8-16 dim range the gain isnt that significant. This shows 2 dim is too restrictive but as dimension increases after a some point, the reconstruction quality becomes stable with minimal performance gain.

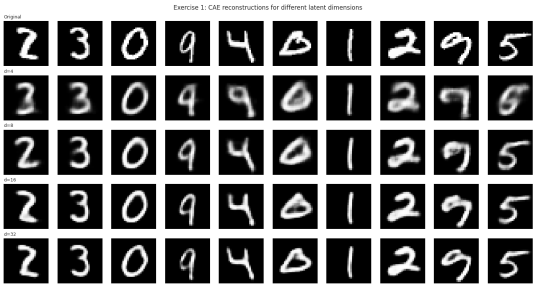
29. Discussion Questions

1. **What is an autoencoder?** An autoencoder is a neural network trained to reproduce its input at the output, learning a compressed intermediate representation (latent code) in the process.
2. **What is the purpose of the encoder?** The encoder maps the input to a lower-dimensional latent representation, compressing the input while preserving essential information.
3. **What is the purpose of the decoder?** The decoder reconstructs the original input from the latent code, translating the compressed representation back to the original space.
4. **What is a latent representation?** A latent representation is a compressed, lower-dimensional encoding of the input that captures its essential features or structure.
5. **Why is the latent representation usually smaller than the input?** A smaller latent dimension forces the autoencoder to learn a compressed representation, acting as a bottleneck that removes noise and irrelevant details.
6. **What happens when the latent dimension is too small?** The model cannot capture enough information, resulting in high reconstruction error and loss of fine details.

7. **What happens when the latent dimension is increased?** Reconstruction quality improves, but the compression ratio decreases and the model requires more parameters and computation.
8. **Why can a convolutional autoencoder preserve spatial information more effectively?** Convolutional layers operate locally on spatial neighborhoods, preserving local structure and relationships between nearby pixels that fully connected layers lose.
9. **Differentiate an autoencoder and a denoising autoencoder.** A standard autoencoder maps clean input to clean output. A denoising autoencoder maps corrupted (noisy) input to clean output, learning to remove noise.
10. **Why is the clean image used as the target in denoising?** Using clean targets trains the model to reconstruct the original signal, effectively learning to separate signal from noise.
11. **What happens when the noise level is increased?** Reconstruction quality degrades, as the model must recover more severely corrupted information; MSE increases and SSIM decreases.
12. **Why are MSE, MAE and SSIM useful for image reconstruction?** MSE measures pixel-level error; MAE is robust to outliers; SSIM captures perceived visual quality and structural similarity.
13. **What is a Variational Autoencoder?** A VAE learns a probabilistic latent distribution, enabling both reconstruction and generation of new samples by sampling from the learned distribution.
14. **How does a VAE differ from a conventional autoencoder?** A VAE maps inputs to a probability distribution (μ, σ) rather than a point; samples are drawn using the reparameterization trick, enabling smooth latent space interpolation.
15. **Why does a VAE learn a distribution instead of a single latent vector?** A distribution enables smooth interpolation and generation, making the latent space continuous and enabling meaningful sample synthesis.
16. **What is the reparameterization trick?** It reformulates $z = \mu + \sigma \odot \epsilon$ to enable backpropagation through the sampling operation by separating the deterministic and stochastic components.
17. **Why is ϵ sampled from a standard normal distribution?** The standard normal provides a universal source of randomness that is transformed by μ and σ to produce samples from the desired distribution.
18. **What is the role of KL divergence in the VAE loss?** KL divergence regularizes the latent distribution to match a standard normal prior, ensuring a smooth, continuous latent space suitable for generation.
19. **What is the prior distribution used in the VAE?** The standard normal distribution $\mathcal{N}(0, I)$, which encourages the learned distribution to be centered and spherical.
20. **Why is a two-dimensional latent space useful for visualization?** A 2D latent space can be directly plotted on a plane, revealing the structure and clustering of different classes in the learned representation.
21. **What does latent-space interpolation demonstrate?** It shows that the latent space is continuous and meaningful: intermediate codes decode to intermediate images, proving smooth transitions between concepts.
22. **Why can a VAE generate new images?** By sampling from the learned latent distribution, the decoder can generate new images that were not in the training set but are similar to the training distribution.
23. **Why might some VAE-generated images be unclear?** High variance in the posterior or a poor reconstruction-KL trade-off can result in blurry or ill-formed images at latent-space boundaries – consistent with the low sample diversity observed in Section 20, where most random samples fell into the same crowded, mixed region of latent space.
24. **What is the difference between reconstruction and generation?** Reconstruction maps a specific input to itself through a learned code; generation creates new, unseen outputs by sampling from the learned distribution.
25. **Why should test images remain unseen during training?** To ensure unbiased evaluation of generalization; using test images during training would overestimate model performance.

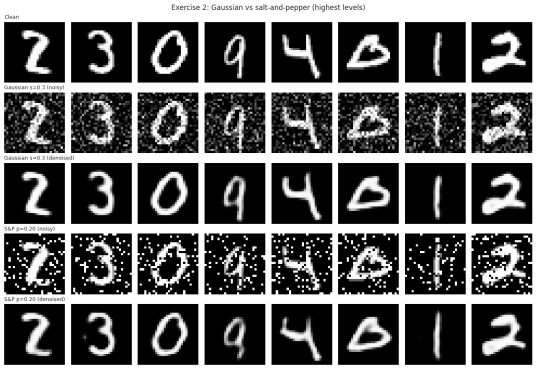
30. Additional Exercises

1. **Train the convolutional autoencoder with latent dimensions of 4, 8, 16 and 32 and compare reconstruction quality.** This study was done on the *fully connected* autoencoder (Section 28) using dimensions $\{4, 8, 16, 32\}$. Result: larger latent dimensions improve reconstruction quality with sharply diminishing returns past $d_z \approx 8$–16 (Section 28). The equivalent study on the *convolutional* autoencoder specifically was not run.



Latent Dimension	MSE	SSIM	Parameters
4	0.032648	0.650933	65797
8	0.019939	0.784	90889
16	0.010265	0.892806	141073
32	0.006515	0.929655	241441

2. **Compare Gaussian noise and salt-and-pepper noise using the same denoising architecture.**



Inference: As noise level increases, denoised SSIM decreases gradually while MSE increases. Salt-Pepper produces more corruption as seen from the high noisy MSE values but because of this it also gives the higher gain than gaussian noise. Overall, the model is able to reconstruct the images very well given any degree of noise level of gaussian and salt-pepper.

Table 1: Gaussian vs. Salt-and-Pepper Noise: Metrics Against Clean Images

Noise Type	**Level**	**Noisy MSE**	**Noisy SSIM**	**Denoised MSE**	**Denoised MAE**	**Denoised SSIM**	**SSIM**
Gaussian	0.10	0.0054	0.6932	0.0029	0.0164	0.9676	0.27
Gaussian	0.20	0.0212	0.6094	0.0042	0.0203	0.9501	0.34
Gaussian	0.30	0.0466	0.5248	0.0064	0.0256	0.9232	0.39
Salt-Pepper	0.05	0.0240	0.7193	0.0037	0.0182	0.9601	0.24
Salt-Pepper	0.10	0.0481	0.5932	0.0045	0.0203	0.9507	0.35
Salt-Pepper	0.20	0.0966	0.4608	0.0069	0.0265	0.9228	0.46

3. **Train the denoising autoencoder using two different noise levels and compare SSIM.**
Inference : Training only on σ=0.1$ performs well on mild noise but degrades sharply on stronger unseen noise. Training on σ=0.3$ generalizes much better across all test noise levels, maintaining SSIM above 0.92. Thus, training with stronger noise improves robustness to varying noise severity, at the cost of slightly worse performance on very mild noise.

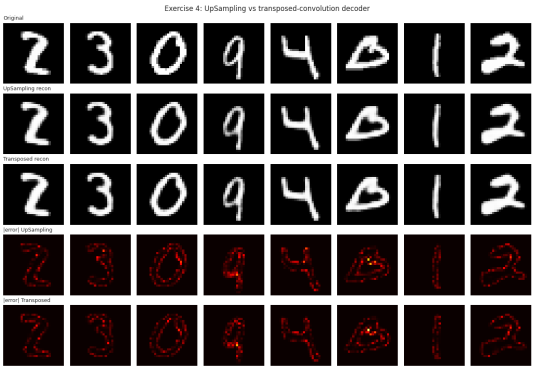
Table 2: SSIM for Different Training and Testing Noise Levels

Training σ	**Test** $\sigma = 0.1$	**Test** $\sigma = 0.2$	**Test** $\sigma = 0.3$
0.1	0.9678	0.8918	0.7172
0.3	0.9546	0.9452	0.9233

Table 3: MSE for Different Training and Testing Noise Levels

Training σ	**Test** $\sigma = 0.1$	**Test** $\sigma = 0.2$	**Test** $\sigma = 0.3$
0.1	0.00288	0.00465	0.00932
0.3	0.00428	0.00491	0.00644

4. **Replace the convolutional decoder with transposed convolutions and compare the reconstructions.**

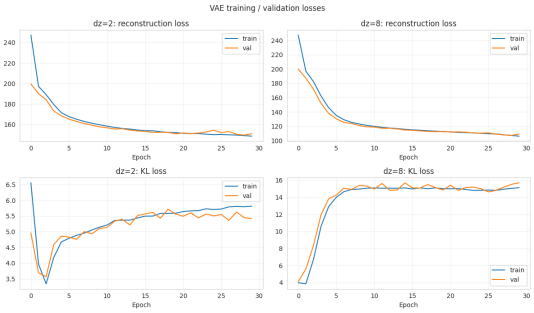


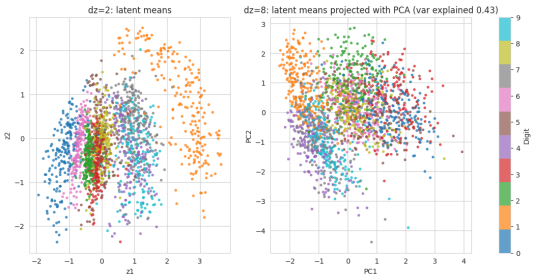
Inference: Conv2DTranspose achieves slightly lower MSE/MAE and higher SSIM, indicating marginally better reconstruction quality. Both architectures have the same number of parameters, while Conv2DTranspose is also faster (17.1 s vs. 19.0 s).

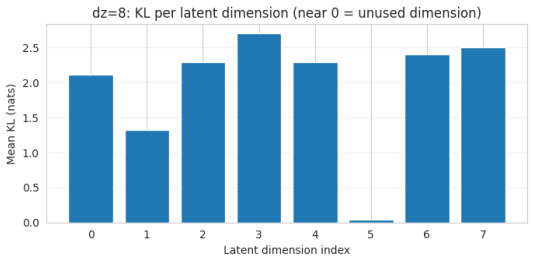
Table 4: Decoder Architecture Comparison

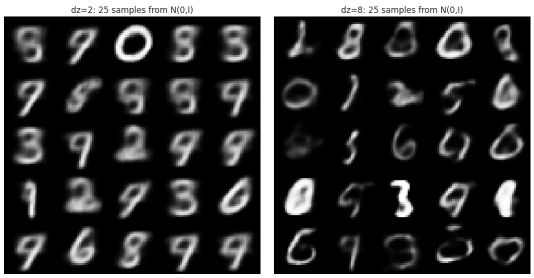
Decoder	MSE	MAE	SSIM	Parameters	Time (s)
UpSampling2D + Conv2D	0.002413	0.014836	0.974513	74497	19.0
Conv2DTranspose	0.002292	0.014157	0.976977	74497	17.1

5. **Implement a VAE with latent dimension 2 and 8 and compare the latent representations.**









Increasing the latent dimension from 2 to 8 substantially improves reconstruction, with SSIM increasing from **0.5064 to 0.7288** and MSE decreasing from **0.0439 to 0.0246**. The 8-dimensional VAE uses **7 active latent dimensions**, while one dimension has very low KL (**0.046**) and is effectively inactive. The additional capacity therefore captures more information about the MNIST images, with only a small increase in parameters and training time.

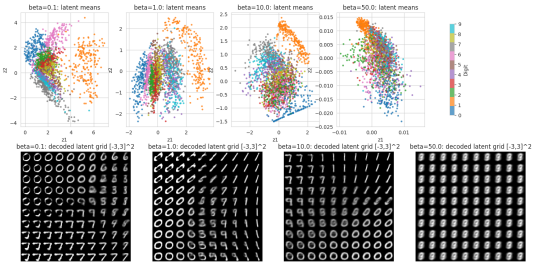
Table 5: VAE Comparison for Different Latent Dimensions

Latent Dim.	Recon Loss	KL Loss	Total Loss	MSE	MAE	SSIM	Parameters	Active Dims.	Tim
2	149.7670	5.4152	155.1822	0.0439	0.1049	0.5064	141189	2	2
8	105.9217	15.6893	121.6110	0.0246	0.0639	0.7288	141489	7	2

Table 6: KL Divergence per Latent Dimension for $d_z = 8$

Dim. 1	Dim. 2	Dim. 3	Dim. 4	Dim. 5	Dim. 6	Dim. 7	Dim. 8
2.119	1.323	2.293	2.701	2.295	0.046	2.405	2.506

6. **Investigate the effect of increasing the KL-loss contribution.**

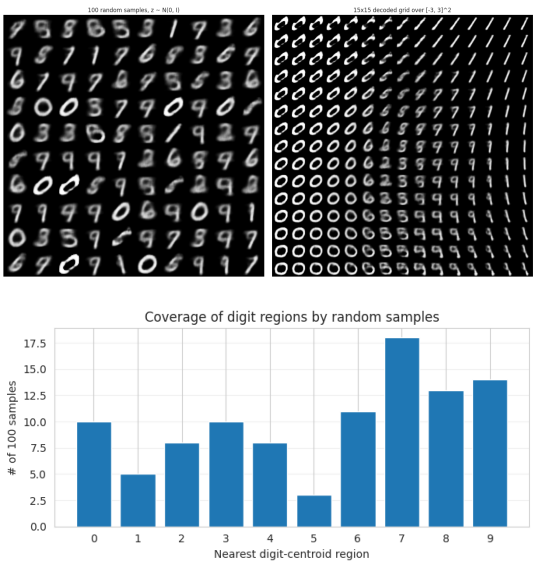


Inference: Increasing β forces the latent distribution closer to the prior, reducing KL divergence and eventually causing **latent collapse** (0 active dimensions at $\beta = 50$). Reconstruction quality is relatively stable for $\beta = 1$, but deteriorates sharply for larger β, with SSIM falling from **0.5064 to 0.1788**. Thus, a moderate β provides a better balance between latent regularization and reconstruction quality.

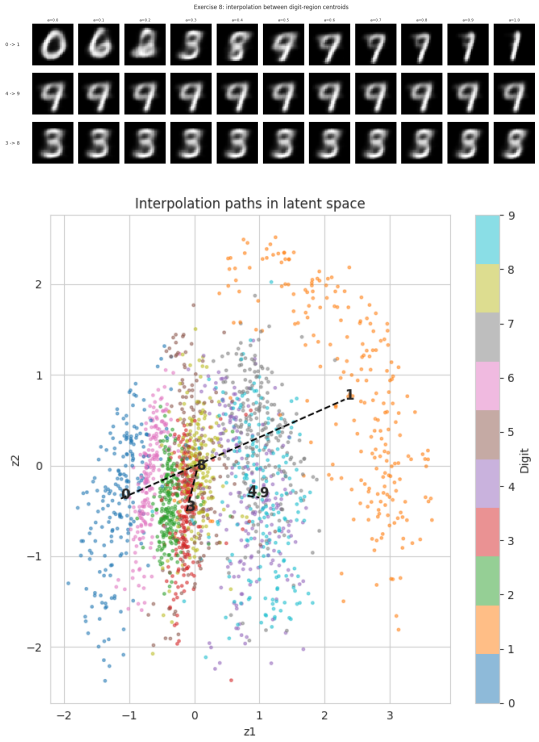
Table 7: Effect of β on VAE Performance

β	Recon Loss	KL Loss	MSE	SSIM	Active Dims.
0.1	149.0002	12.0877	0.0439	0.5043	2
1.0	149.7670	5.4152	0.0439	0.5064	2
10.0	164.4278	1.7802	0.0504	0.3969	2
50.0	203.9250	0.0001	0.0667	0.1788	0

7. **Generate a larger grid of VAE samples and discuss diversity.**



8. Inference: **The 100 random samples demonstrate that the 2D VAE can generate diverse MNIST-like digits from random latent vectors, covering multiple digit classes and styles. The samples are not equally distributed across all digit regions, with digit 7 being the most represented and digit 5 the least represented, indicating uneven coverage of the latent space. The smooth transitions in the 15×15 latent grid further show that nearby latent points produce gradually changing digit structures.**
9. **Select two digit regions in the latent space and perform interpolation.**



Inference: Linear interpolation between digit-region centroids produces smooth transitions between latent representations, with the generated images gradually changing from one digit to another. This indicates that the VAE has learned a continuous and structured latent space where nearby regions correspond to related digit representations. However because of overlaps in as seen earlier, the 4 ¿ 9 row shows the first image(as well as the rest) as a 9, inidcating significant overlaps betweent the 4 and 9 clusters in latent space.

31. Expected Outcome

At the end of the experiment, students should be able to demonstrate the complete image-representation and reconstruction pipeline:

$$\boxed{\text{Image} \rightarrow \text{Encoder} \rightarrow \text{Latent Representation} \rightarrow \text{Decoder} \rightarrow \text{Reconstructed Image}}$$

They should also demonstrate denoising:

$$\boxed{\text{Clean Image} \rightarrow \text{Noise} \rightarrow \text{Denoising Autoencoder} \rightarrow \text{Recovered Image}}$$

and variational generation:

$$\boxed{\text{Image} \rightarrow (\mu, \sigma) \rightarrow z \rightarrow \text{Decoder} \rightarrow \text{Generated/Reconstructed Image}}$$

Key results from this run:

- FC Autoencoder: fast to train, but visibly blurry, thicker-stroked reconstructions (SSIM 0.7621) due to loss of spatial structure through flattening.
- Convolutional AE: sharp, high-fidelity reconstructions (SSIM 0.9746) leveraging spatial locality, using only 35% as many parameters as the FC model.
- Denoising CAE: effectively removes Gaussian noise and recovers digit structure across all tested noise levels (SSIM 0.89–0.96 for $\sigma = 0.1$–0.3).

- VAE: enables smooth latent-space interpolation (Section 21) and generation, but with a 2D latent space and a 10-class dataset, the learned latent space under-separates most digit classes (Section 19), which in turn produces generated samples with visibly limited diversity (Section 20) and the weakest reconstruction metrics of the four models (SSIM 0.4865).

The final report contains both quantitative evaluation and visual analysis. All numerical values above were obtained from the student's own notebook execution.

32. References

1. Ian Goodfellow, Yoshua Bengio and Aaron Courville, *Deep Learning*, MIT Press, 2016.
2. Diederik P. Kingma and Max Welling, "Auto-Encoding Variational Bayes," ICLR, 2014.
3. Pascal Vincent et al., "Stacked Denoising Autoencoders: Learning Useful Representations in a Deep Network with a Local Denoising Criterion," Journal of Machine Learning Research, 2010.
4. Yann LeCun, Corinna Cortes and Christopher J. C. Burges, "MNIST Handwritten Digit Database."
5. TensorFlow Documentation: `https://www.tensorflow.org`
6. Keras Documentation: `https://keras.io`
7. scikit-image Documentation: `https://scikit-image.org`